

and also raise the bar in capital formation and providing information. Our regulators have also played an important role in the ecosystem, given their forward-thinking approach. In terms of corporate governance and investor protection as well, we are among the best in the world. Since Independence, this is the first time that we are not being taken over by circumstances. India is now much evolved in terms of mindset.

Q: Where do stock exchanges feature in the larger scheme of economic development?

A: Our job is to act as frontline regulators and also provide services for transactions in stocks. These are the two large jobs wherein one provides liquidity and the other creates trust. The primary function that an exchange does in any economy is provide clean and sharp prices along with sharp and authentic information to make the market robust and efficient. Our job is taking information from the companies and putting it out quickly and ensuring that trading, clearing and settlement happen without any glitch. But since people think we are an authority and a regulator, they ascribe many powers to us that we do not have. Young investors today have more money to spend, which is creating demand. They also have more money to invest and save and that is where we need to help inculcate better investment behaviour, which will allow them to save for their retirement, children's education, etc. That is the duty of any exchange or regulator—point them in the right direction and, if needed, make regulations that nudge them to do so.

Q: How can more savings be channelled towards investments?

A: Creating awareness is important and between the established exchanges today, a large number of investor awareness campaigns are done every year. More importantly, it is also about examples... investors who stay disciplined and stay within the regulatory framework, and make money. When society sees those examples, they want to emulate them. Today, we have more than 80 million investors. When I joined this industry around 30 years ago, there were hardly 2.5-3 million investors... As a society, even as we are more socialist in nature and give more importance to banking and less importance to the market, market-based capital allocation accounts for one-third of our wealth. That clearly shows that an increasing number of people are coming to the markets. As an exchange, the aim is to ensure we bring them to safer instruments, especially when they are entering the markets. Hence, we promote mutual funds and port-



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folio management services that have the expertise to manage money.

Q: How do you see the compliance level among Indian corporates in terms of ESG?

A: Whenever a new regulation comes, companies comply in different ways and that is bound to happen based on their level of preparedness. On an overall basis, Indian corporates broadly comply with all regulations... In fact, many of our regulations are way ahead when compared to some of the developed markets. For instance, women's representation on the board, and contribution of a part of the profits towards CSR, among other things. Our policymakers and regulators are quick in implementing [these].

Q: You joined NSE at a time when it was facing